writing it in a government committee report, but nothing ever got done without it being repeatedly written into multiple government committee reports.

Stage 5 of the policy pipeline is the internal government process of decision making. This is where ministers and senior bureaucrats take stock of the range of possible policy pathways and make decisions. This is the zone of political economy, and the creative trade-offs that make progress possible.

Stage 6 of the policy pipeline is the translation of the decisions into legal instruments. Most policy decisions must be implemented through law that is enacted by the legislature, or subordinate legislation in the form of rules or regulations. High technical quality, and subtle detail, of this drafting process is of great importance.

In India, all too often, the drafting of law is done by persons who have a superficial understanding of the prior stages of the policy pipeline, which leads to poor drafting of law.

Finally, *stage 7* of the policy pipeline is the construction of state capacity, in the form of administrative structures that enforce the law.

Looking back into our history, the successful reforms in India were those that fared well on all seven elements of the policy pipeline. This, in turn, required capacity building in all the stages. It is only when there were human capabilities on all seven stages of the pipeline, and enough time had been given for working through these stages, that we got a sound reform.

An alternative depiction of the policy process

The economist Satya Poddar has a different conception of the policy process, which is also illuminating. He thinks in terms of a four-part story:

1. Defining the future state, or the preferred policy outcome,
2. Preparing a blueprint for the design and specification of the future state,